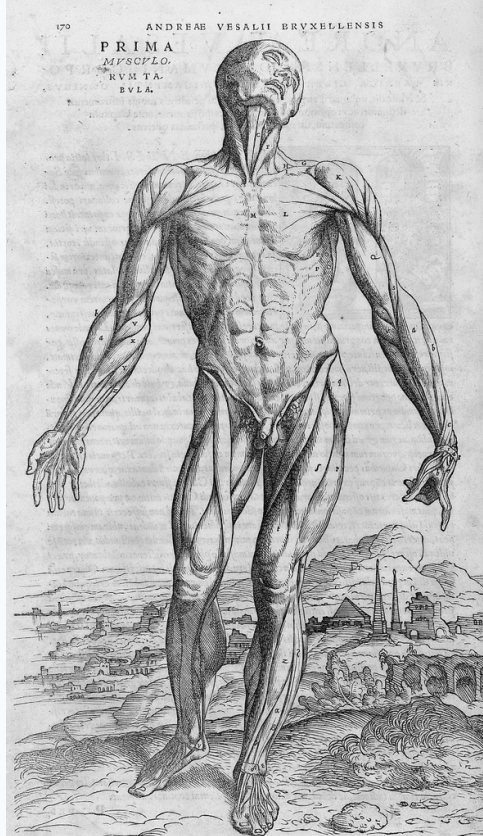




MEONCROSS SCHOOL | HISTORY DEPARTMENT

EDITION 2026.1

DID THE RENAISSANCE TRULY REVOLUTIONISE MEDICINE, OR WAS IT ALL TALK?

*Paper 1: Medicine Through Time with the Western
Front – Renaissance*

Scholar: _____

Class: _____

Edexcel Specification: c1500–c1700

- **1. Causes of disease:** Continuity of the Four Humours; new ideas from Vesalius and Harvey.
- **2. Treatments:** Continuity of Galenic remedies; new chemical cures (Paracelsus).
- **3. Impact of the Renaissance:** The printing press, the Royal Society, and scientific method.
- **4. Case Study: The Great Plague (1665):** Causes, responses, and impact.

PROGRESS & ASSESSMENT TRACKER

TARGET GRADE: _____

Grade	9-1 GCSE Grading Scale		
Lesson / Assessment Title	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments
L1: KT2.1: Did the Renaissance change beliefs about the causes of illness?			
L2: KT2.2: Did treatments improve during the Renaissance?			
L3: KT2.3: How significant were William Harvey and the Great Plague?			
Final Unit Grade:			

L1: KT2.1: Did the Renaissance change beliefs about the causes of illness?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how Thomas Sydenham's scientific approach to observation changed the diagnosis of disease.
- ☐ Assess the role of the printing press and the Royal Society in communicating and spreading scientific ideas.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

In what year did the Black Death arrive in England?

Who were the 'flagellants'?

State one common medieval preventative measure for the Black Death.

What are the four humours?

What was 'miasma'?

Which Roman physician developed the Theory of Opposites?

How did medieval hospitals differ from modern ones?

What was the purpose of 'bleeding' (phlebotomy) in medieval medicine?

What was the role of a medieval apothecary?

How did the medieval Church explain the cause of disease?

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Circle ONE term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?

Humanism | Nullius in Verba | Animalcules | Royal Society | Andreas Vesalius | Printing Press

Q1. Andreas Vesalius and Human Anatomy

GCSE TWO-SIDED ARGUMENT

GCSE Analytical Assessment: Evaluate both the revolutionary anatomical breakthroughs and the critical practical limitations of Vesalius.

▲ Breakthrough & Advancement (Change)	■ Critical Limitations & Stagnation (Continuity)
- Overthrew 1,300 years of dogmatic medical tradition by performing human dissections himself in Padua rather than lecturing from Galen in an elevated chair. - Corrected over 300 of Galen's anatomical errors in De Humani Corporis Fabrica (1543), proving Galen dissected animals (e.g. human lower jaw is 1 bone, breastbone has 3 parts, heart septum has no pores). - Published extraordinarily detailed, mathematically accurate woodcut illustrations using the printing press, standardizing empirical anatomical training across European universities. <i>Starter: "On the one hand, Andreas Vesalius made revolutionary breakthroughs in Renaissance medicine because..."</i>	- Anatomical corrections did NOT cure a single disease, heal patients, or prevent deadly epidemics like the plague. - Vesalius did not understand the causes of disease (microbes and infection remained completely unknown for another 300 years). - Everyday medical treatments experienced zero change: bloodletting, purging, and the Theory of the Four Humours remained standard practice. - Traditional physicians fiercely resisted his findings; some claimed the human body had deformed since Galen's time rather than admit Galen was wrong. <i>Counter: "However, the practical significance of Vesalius was severely limited because..."</i>

GCSE Paragraph Builder: Write a balanced GCSE exam paragraph evaluating how far Andreas Vesalius transformed medicine in the Renaissance.

Connectives: Although... • However, in practical terms... • Consequently, while anatomy advanced... • Overall, his impact was limited to...

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q2)

How did Sydenham's belief that diseases were like plants or animals challenge the traditional Theory of the Four Humours?

- ☐ A. It proved that diseases were caused by invisible germs.
- ☐ B. It meant diseases were separate entities with specific symptoms, rather than a personal imbalance of a patient's humours.
- ☐ C. It showed that diseases could only be cured by herbal remedies.
- ☐ D. It proved that diseases were a punishment from God.

Q3. Thomas Sydenham and Bedside Diagnosis

GCSE TWO-SIDED ARGUMENT

GCSE Analytical Assessment: Evaluate both the diagnostic advancements and the practical treatment limitations of Thomas Sydenham.

▲ Diagnostic Advancement (Change)	■ Critical Limitations & Continuity
- Rejected book-based theoretical medicine in favor of direct clinical bedside observation, earning the title 'the English Hippocrates'. - Argued that diseases were distinct external entities (like botanical plant species) that could be classified by observing symptom clusters across different patients. - Successfully distinguished scarlet fever from measles as two entirely separate diseases in <i>Observationes Medicae</i> (1676). - Introduced rational practical treatments: prescribed cinchona bark (quinine) for malaria and advocated cool bedrooms and fresh air for smallpox rather than heavy sweating blankets. <i>Starter: "On the one hand, Thomas Sydenham significantly advanced medical diagnosis because..."</i>	- Had zero understanding of microorganisms or germs; still believed disease was caused by atmospheric miasma (bad air) and environmental vapors. - Could not explain the true biological cause of illnesses, meaning his classification was based purely on external symptoms rather than internal pathogens. - Continued to rely on traditional humoral treatments for many illnesses, including bleeding and purging patients. - Conservative physicians in London ridiculed his methods, refusing to abandon the traditional individualized Four Humours theory. <i>Counter: "However, the practical impact of Sydenham was limited because..."</i>

GCSE Paragraph Builder: Write a balanced GCSE exam paragraph evaluating the extent to which Thomas Sydenham revolutionized medicine in the 17th century.

Connectives: Although Sydenham transformed diagnosis... • However, regarding treatments... • Consequently... • Therefore, while his methodology pointed forward...

Q4. The Printing Press and Medical Communication

GCSE TWO-SIDED ARGUMENT

GCSE Analytical Assessment: Evaluate both the revolutionary impact of the printing press and its historical limitations.

▲ Communication Revolution (Change)	■ Practical Limitations & Continuity
- Invented by Johannes Gutenberg (c1440), it mass-produced identical books rapidly and cheaply, ending the Catholic Church's scribal monopoly and censorship. - Allowed medical discoveries—such as Vesalius' <i>De Fabrica</i> (1543)—to be published and distributed simultaneously to university medical faculties across Europe. - Eliminated copying errors common in hand-transcribed manuscripts and allowed precise anatomical woodcuts and diagrams to be reproduced identically. <i>Starter: "On the one hand, the printing press transformed the communication of medical knowledge because..."</i>	- Books remained expensive luxury items that only wealthy physicians, aristocrats, and universities could afford. - The vast majority of ordinary people across Europe were illiterate and unable to read Latin medical treatises. - Printing houses also mass-produced traditional astrological almanacs, medieval herbals, and classical Galenic texts, entrenching old superstitions among the public. - Spreading ideas did not automatically lead to better healthcare, as ordinary barber-surgeons and apothecaries had no formal university training. <i>Counter: "However, the impact of the printing press on everyday healthcare was limited because..."</i>

GCSE Paragraph Builder: Write a balanced GCSE exam paragraph explaining why the printing press changed medical communication while having limited immediate effect on public health.

Connectives: While the printing press enabled unprecedented spread of research... • Nevertheless, for the wider population... • This meant that... • Ultimately...

Q5. The Royal Society and Scientific Progress

GCSE TWO-SIDED ARGUMENT

GCSE Analytical Assessment: Evaluate both the institutional breakthrough of the Royal Society and its practical limitations.

▲ Institutional Breakthrough (Change)	■ Practical Limitations & Continuity
- Founded in London in 1660 and granted a Royal Charter by King Charles II (1662), giving state prestige and funding to experimental science. - Operated under the radical motto 'Nullius in Verba' ('Take nobody's word for it'), rejecting ancient classical authority in favor of hands-on experimental proof and demonstration. - Published the world's first scientific journal, Philosophical Transactions (1665), establishing an international network for peer review and disseminating discoveries. - Supported Antonie van Leeuwenhoek's microscopic observations of 'animalcules' (bacteria) in 1676/1683 and Robert Hooke's Micrographia (1665). <i>Starter: "On the one hand, the Royal Society accelerated medical and scientific progress because..."</i>	- Functioned as an exclusive gentleman's debating club for wealthy amateurs; it ran no hospitals, dispensaries, or clinics to treat patients. - Leeuwenhoek's microscopic "animalcules" were viewed as fascinating curiosities rather than recognized as the causes of disease. - The Society focused heavily on physics, astronomy, mechanics, and chemistry, with medicine remaining largely unregulated and unscientific in daily practice. - Ordinary sick Londoners continued to visit quack doctors, apothecaries, and wise women, untouched by elite scientific lectures. <i>Counter: "However, the practical contribution of the Royal Society to saving lives was limited because..."</i>
GCSE Paragraph Builder: Write a balanced GCSE exam paragraph evaluating the extent to which the Royal Society transformed medicine between 1660 and 1700. Connectives: On the one hand, the Royal Society institutionalized empirical science... • However, in terms of practical patient care... • Because microbes were not understood as pathogens... • Therefore, its immediate medical impact was...	

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. Prompt: In the period c1500-c1700, was the work of individual physicians like Thomas Sydenham more important in challenging traditional medical beliefs than institutional developments like the founding of the Royal Society?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (e.g., Sydenham's Observationes Medicae classifying diseases like scarlet fever vs. the Royal Society publishing Leeuwenhoek's discoveries in Philosophical Transactions).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Pace of Change in Renaissance Medicine

Historians often debate the extent to which the Renaissance c1500-c1700 represented a genuine breakthrough or a period of stagnation in the understanding of disease causes. Traditional historians emphasize a 'Scientific Revolution,' pointing to the works of Vesalius, Harvey, and Leeuwenhoek as a rapid and complete dismantling of medieval Galenism.

However, revisionist historians argue that this period was actually characterized by overwhelming continuity for the average patient. They argue that while elite physicians in organizations like the Royal Society debated new ideas, daily treatments (such as bleeding and purging to balance the humours) remained completely unchanged. Because there was no scientific proof that Leeuwenhoek's 'animalcules' actually caused disease, everyday medical practice clung tightly to the Theory of the Four Humours and miasma for centuries after the Renaissance.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q7. Explain one way in which ideas about the causes of disease in the Renaissance period (c1500–c1700) were similar to ideas about the causes of disease in the medieval period (c1250–c1500).

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Q8. Explain why there were changes in the way ideas about the causes of disease and illness were communicated in the period c1500–c1700.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

[illegible]

[illegible]

Q9. Explain why there were changes in the way ideas about the causes of disease and illness were communicated in the period c1500-c1700.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- The printing press
- The Royal Society

You must also use information of your own.

- The printing press
- The Royal Society

You must also use information of your own.

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L2: KT2.2: Did treatments improve during the Renaissance?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Analyze the continuities and changes in Renaissance treatments and preventions, including the impact of exploration and alchemy.
- ☐ Explain how institutional changes, specifically the Dissolution of the Monasteries, altered hospital care in England.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

What was the Renaissance?

What invention helped spread new medical ideas during the Renaissance?

Who was Thomas Sydenham?

Who wrote 'On the Fabric of the Human Body' (1543)?

What did Vesalius prove about Galen's anatomical ideas?

In what year did the Black Death arrive in England?

Explain the role of the apothecary in medieval medicine.

Why did the influence of the Church begin to decline in the Renaissance?

What was the Royal Society?

What was 'miasma'?

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):

Transference | Iatrochemistry | Thomas Sydenham | Pharmacopoeia | Dissolution of the Monasteries | Pest House

Q1. Continuity and Change in Renaissance Treatments (c1500–c1700)

GCSE TWO-SIDED ARGUMENT

GCSE Analytical Assessment: Evaluate the extent to which medical treatments improved during the Renaissance (c1500–c1700).

▲ Medical Innovations & New Treatments (Change)	■ Persistent Tradition & Severe Limitations (Continuity)
- Global exploration introduced new botanical treatments from the Americas, such as Cinchona bark (containing quinine) to treat malarial fevers and sarsaparilla for syphilis. - The growth of alchemy spurred iatrochemistry (medical chemistry), popularized by Paracelsus, introducing mineral-based chemical cures like antimony to purge the body. - Thomas Sydenham advocated empirical clinical observation, urging physicians to identify and treat specific diseases rather than isolated individual symptoms. <i>Starter: “On the one hand, medical treatments experienced important changes during the Renaissance because...”</i>	- The vast majority of physicians and patients still firmly believed in the Four Humours, continuing to rely on bleeding, purging, and sweating to balance bodily fluids. - Without an understanding of Germ Theory or microscopy, physicians could not identify the microscopic causes of infectious disease, leaving treatments powerless against epidemics. - Superstitious remedies persisted, such as transference (attempting to pass an illness to an animal or object) and royal touch for the King’s Evil. - Dangerous chemical cures like antimony and toxic mercury often poisoned patients, while the closure of monastic hospitals left ordinary people dependent on unlicensed quacks. <i>Counter: “However, there was massive continuity in medical treatment because...”</i>

GCSE Paragraph Builder: Write a balanced GCSE exam paragraph evaluating the extent of change in medical treatments during the Renaissance (c1500–c1700).

Connectives: Although global trade and iatrochemistry introduced novel remedies... • However, because the Four Humours remained entrenched... • This directly resulted in... • Overall, continuity heavily outweighed change because...

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q2)

Why was the importation of cinchona bark from South America a more successful treatment than traditional humoral methods?

- ☐ A. It contained quinine, which actually treated the specific symptoms of malaria, rather than just attempting to rebalance humours.
- ☐ B. It was a holy relic blessed by the Pope.
- ☐ C. It killed the germs that caused malaria.
- ☐ D. It was used to draw bad humours out of the skin.

Q3. Describe the approach of Thomas Sydenham.

Q4. Explain why treatments for ordinary people hardly changed during the Renaissance.

Q5. Describe one way apothecaries or surgeons became more professional during the Renaissance.

Q6. To what extent did the 'New World' improve medical treatments?

Pair & Share Activity

Q7. Prompt: In the period c1500-c1700, did the introduction of global herbal remedies and chemical cures represent a more significant improvement in treatment than the gradual reforms made to the training of physicians?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (such as the successful use of cinchona bark for malaria versus the fact that physicians' training was still largely book-based with very little hands-on dissection experience).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over Renaissance Progress: Breakthrough or Backstep?

Historians actively debate whether the Renaissance represented genuine progress in patient care or a period of regression. Traditionalist accounts often celebrated the 'rebirth' of medical science, highlighting how the shift towards chemical cures and Vesalian anatomy laid the foundations of modern clinical practice. However, revisionist social historians argue that for the average sick person, the Renaissance was actually a time of decline in care. They point out that Henry VIII's closure of the monasteries in 1536 destroyed the medieval hospital safety net, leaving thousands of poor patients without any institutional care. Furthermore, they highlight that some new treatments, such as using highly toxic mercury to treat syphilis or smoking tobacco as a 'cure-all' defense against plague, actually did far more physical harm than medieval herbal remedies ever did.

Q8. Explain why there was little change in medical treatments during the Renaissance period (c1500-c1700), despite new anatomical discoveries.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

[illegible]

[illegible]

Q9. Explain one way in which medical treatments in the Renaissance period (c1500-c1700) were similar to medical treatments in the medieval period (c1250-c1500).

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Q10. Explain why there was rapid progress in anatomical knowledge in the Renaissance period (c1500-c1700).

[12 marks • 15 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- Andreas Vesalius
- The printing press

You must also use information of your own.

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This image shows a full page of blank, lined paper. It features approximately 28 horizontal blue or grey lines spaced evenly apart, typical of notebook paper. The lines extend across the entire width of the page, leaving small margins at the top and bottom. There are no vertical lines, text, or other markings on the page.

General Notes

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L3: KT2.3: How significant were William Harvey and the Great Plague?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the significance of William Harvey's discovery and the reasons for its limited short-term impact.
- ☐ Compare the government and public responses to the 1665 Great Plague with the 1348 Black Death.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

Who wrote 'On the Fabric of the Human Body' (1543)?

What did Vesalius prove about Galen's anatomical ideas?

What was 'transference'?

What was the Royal Society?

Why did the influence of the Church begin to decline in the Renaissance?

In what year did the Great Plague hit London?

How did local mayors try to prevent the spread of the Black Death in 1348?

What was the Theory of the Four Humours?

What was the purpose of 'bleeding' (phlebotomy) in medieval medicine?

What was the role of a medieval apothecary?

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:

Circulation William Harvey Great Plague Bills of Mortality Searchers Plague Doctor	
Power, Governance & Warfare	Economy, Trade & Society

Q1. William Harvey and Blood Circulation

GCSE TWO-SIDED ARGUMENT

GCSE Analytical Assessment: Evaluate both the revolutionary physiology of William Harvey and its total lack of practical treatment impact.

▲ Physiological Breakthrough (Change) - Proved in De Motu Cordis (1628) that blood circulates continuously around the body in a closed one-way system pumped by the muscular heart. - Completely disproved Galen's 1,400-year theory that the liver constantly manufactures new blood from food that is consumed by the tissues. - Used rigorous mechanical calculations and simple tourniquet experiments on human arms to prove blood must be recycled and that veins contain one-way valves. <i>Starter: "On the one hand, William Harvey made a momentous breakthrough in physiology because..."</i>	■ Critical Limitations & Zero Cures - Harvey's discovery did NOT lead to a single new medical treatment, cure, or surgical technique during his lifetime. - Did not know about microscopic capillaries (invisible without powerful microscopes) connecting arteries and veins; Malpighi only proved them in 1661. - Doctors continued bleeding patients using phlebotomy and leeches for another 200 years, completely ignoring the reality of closed circulation. - Contemporary physicians called Harvey a madman and a "circulator" (quack); many of his private patients abandoned him. <i>Counter: "However, Harvey's discovery had almost no practical significance for patients because..."</i>
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GCSE Paragraph Builder: Write a balanced GCSE exam paragraph evaluating the significance of William Harvey's discovery of the circulation of blood.

Connectives: On the one hand, Harvey dismantled classical physiology... • However, in terms of practical medicine and patient survival... • Because bloodletting continued unabated... • Therefore, his significance was theoretical rather than clinical...

Q2. Identify what William Harvey proved about the blood.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

What was the main reason why Harvey's discovery of blood circulation did not immediately change medical treatments?

- ☐ A. Because he refused to publish his findings in a book.
- ☐ B. Because the Church banned his book and executed him.
- ☐ C. Because knowing how the blood circulated did not provide doctors with any new drugs or cures for sick patients.

☐ D. Because he still believed the liver manufactured blood.

Q4. The Response to the Great Plague of 1665

GCSE TWO-SIDED ARGUMENT

GCSE Analytical Assessment: Evaluate the advancements in government organization against the ongoing medical ignorance of the 1665 plague.

▲ Government Organization (Change)

- The Lord Mayor of London issued strict quarantine orders: infected houses locked for 28 days with red crosses and watchmen.
- Killed over 40,000 stray dogs and cats believed to carry miasma or infection; banned public gatherings, theatres, and funerals.
- Weekly Bills of Mortality recorded exact plague casualties across parishes, representing early statistical epidemiology.

Starter: "On the one hand, the government response to the Great Plague was far more organized than in 1348 because..."

■ Medical Ignorance & Superstition (Continuity)

- People and physicians were still completely ignorant of the true cause (*Yersinia pestis* transmitted by rat fleas); killing cats and dogs actually allowed the rat population to explode.
- Miasma, astrological alignment, and God's wrath remained the primary explanations.
- Treatments were completely useless: strapping plucked chickens or dried toads to buboes, drinking plague water with mercury, and forcing schoolboys to smoke tobacco.
- Over 100,000 Londoners (20% of the population) died; the epidemic was ended by winter cold and quarantine, not medical science.

Counter: "However, the medical response to the Great Plague remained fundamentally medieval because..."

GCSE Paragraph Builder: Write a balanced GCSE exam paragraph explaining why the 1665 response was an administrative success but a medical failure.

Connectives: Although municipal quarantine was strictly enforced... • Nevertheless, from a clinical perspective... • Crucially, because rat fleas were unknown... • Ultimately...

Q5. Explain how the Great Plague of 1665 was dealt with differently from the Black Death.

Q6. Evaluate the short-term significance of Harvey's discovery.

Pair & Share Activity

Q7. Prompt: Why was William Harvey's brilliant discovery of blood circulation completely ignored in the prevention and treatment of the Great Plague of 1665?

Think: Jot down your explanation and one piece of evidence (e.g., how knowing that blood flows did not help cure a disease when germs were still undiscovered, or how doctors did not

believe Harvey because they felt it had no practical clinical application).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Significance of William Harvey

Historians often debate whether William Harvey represents a sudden turning point or a very gradual stepping stone in medicine. Traditionalist historians celebrate his work as a revolutionary breakthrough that demolished Galenic physiology. However, revisionist historians emphasize the extreme limits of his immediate significance. They point out that a lot of contemporary doctors simply ignored or openly criticized Harvey because his discovery offered no practical treatment for sick patients. As a result, English medical textbooks continued to print Galen's flawed theories until 1651, and Harvey's findings were not taught in universities until 1673, decades after his discovery.

Q8. Explain why the government's response to the Great Plague of 1665 was more effective than its response to the Black Death of 1348.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

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[illegible]

Q9. Explain one way in which the response to the Great Plague in London (1665) was different from the response to the Black Death (1348).

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Q10. 'The most effective method of preventing the spread of the Great Plague (1665) was the use of quarantine.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

[20 marks • 25 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- Watchmen
- The animal cull

You must also use information of your own.

- Watchmen
- The animal cull

You must also use information of your own.

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End of Unit Reflection & Pupil Voice

Unit: Paper 1: Medicine Through Time

Instructions: Now that you have completed your final assessment, take 10 minutes to reflect on your learning across this entire unit. Be honest—this is your chance to use your **Pupil Voice** to help your teacher plan future lessons.

1. What Went Well (WWW)

What topic or skill did you find most engaging or easiest to understand in this unit?

2. Even Better If (EBI)

What did you find most challenging? Are there any concepts you are still confused about?

3. Effort & Target Setting

Circle your effort level for this unit: **1 (Low)** **2** **3** **4** **5 (Excellent)**

What is one specific target you want to set for yourself in the next unit?

Teacher Feedback & Coaching

(To be completed during live marking / feedback lessons)

Factors Overview: Renaissance

Edexcel focuses heavily on the factors that drove medical progress (or held it back). For each factor below, write one specific historical example from this period that either helped or hindered medical progress.

Factor	Specific Historical Example & Impact
Individuals	
The Church & Religion	
Government & Wealth	
Science & Technology	
Attitudes in Society	
War	